12

FREEDOM STRUGGLE AND PARTITION

From Gandhi’s Critique to the Kakori Train Robbery

India’s freedom struggle had its own relationship with the railways. Railway assets were a formidable sign of the empire in the country and discrimination against Indians on trains and railways were always taken up aggressively in the fight against the British. Mahatma Gandhi had been one of the staunchest critics of the travel conditions for the lower classes, and his essay on third class train travel is an inseparable part of the railway history of the era.

THE MAHATMA’S JOURNEYS IN THIRD CLASS COACHES

‘Third Class in Indian Railways’ by M.K. Gandhi Ranchi, 25 September, 1917 :

> I have now been in India for over two years and a half after my return from South Africa. Over one quarter of that time I have passed on the Indian trains travelling third class by choice. I have travelled up north as far as Lahore, down south up to Tranquebar, and from Karachi to Calcutta. Having resorted to third class travelling, among other reasons, for the purpose of studying the conditions under which this class of passengers travels, I have naturally made as many critical observations as I could. I have fairly covered the majority of railway systems during this period. Now and then I have entered into correspondence with the management of the different railways about the defects that have come under my notice. But I think that the time has come when I should invite the press and the public to join in a crusade against a grievance which has too long remained unredressed, though much of it is capable of redress without great difficulty.
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> On the twelfth instant I booked at Bombay for Madras by the mail train and paid 13.9 rupees. It was labelled to carry twenty-two passengers. These could only have seating